

Friday — Run Sheet

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Everything you need for Friday, in one place, in order. Print this.

BEFORE YOU WALK IN

The biggest risk Friday is that Joshua recites his document. He spent days writing sixteen pages of well-organized abstraction, and he'll naturally reach for those answers when asked anything. Abstraction is what we already have. Specifics are what we need. So don't circulate an agenda, and don't open by discussing his document. Tell them it's a working session about how the firm actually operates day to day.

Record it, with everyone's permission. You can't run a good interview and take good notes at once, and the exact words people use are the raw material for the brand voice.

How to frame it when you sit down, something close to: "I read your document twice and there's a lot in there. Today I want to do the opposite of it, though. It's all at thirty thousand feet and I need to get down on the ground, so I'm going to ask a lot of small, specific questions about actual clients and actual days."

WHAT TO BRING

- This run sheet, printed. Not a laptop.
- Your phone or a recorder, storage checked beforehand.
- The client-base spreadsheet, to hand over at the end.
- Nothing branded. No slides, no visual concepts, no name treatments.

THE FOUR HABITS

1. **Trade every abstraction for an example.** "We build trust" becomes "tell me about the last time a client trusted you with something they were embarrassed about." Every time, even when it feels repetitive.
2. **Let silence run.** Count to five after someone finishes. The first answer is rehearsed, the second is true, and the second only comes if you don't fill the gap.
3. **Ask "what happened next" a few times.** Most of the useful detail lives a few follow-ups past where people naturally stop.
4. **Write down exact phrasing.** When someone says something in plain regional language, stop and note it verbatim.

When Joshua starts quoting his own document, and he will: "Right, and I read that part. Give me the client that made you write it."

One thing to avoid. Don't debate the tagline, the name, or the niche during the open questions. Collect input, write it down, move on. If that debate starts at minute twenty it will eat the whole session, and none of you have the client data yet that would actually settle it.

This sheet runs in one order, start to finish: the business, then the clients, then referrals, the market, the name, the team, the character exercise, Waynesburg, then the 25th logistics, then Tim and Hayley, then the founder interview alone with Joshua. If time runs short, protect the first two sections and the founder interview above everything else. Everything else can happen by phone later, or on the site.

THE BUSINESS

Start here, and start simple. This is the section where you're building your own understanding of the industry as much as anyone else's understanding of the firm, so don't rush past it.

1. **Ask this literally first, before anything else:** Walk me through what you do here, what the business actually does, day to day. I have no background in this industry, so assume nothing.
2. How are you paid? A percentage of assets, a flat fee, something else, and does it change by client or account size?
3. You're technically a fiduciary. What does that actually mean day to day, and do you ever use that word with clients? *Worth knowing going in: a fiduciary is legally required to act in the client's best interest, unlike a broker or insurance agent held only to a lower "suitability" standard. It's one of the few real, defensible differentiators the industry has — useful to know whether it's already part of how he talks about the firm.*
4. When you say "financial plan," is there an actual document a client receives? What does the relationship look like after that, meetings, reviews, calls?
5. If a client asked you what makes you different from a broker or an insurance agent, what would you actually say?

Now confirm the specifics you already have on paper, out loud.

6. Confirm, don't ask cold: independent RIA in Waynesburg, bought by Joshuah in December 2025, growth almost entirely referral-driven, average client in their 60s. Anything wrong or incomplete in that?
7. Confirm the numbers: roughly \$135M AUM, 210+ households, about 40% growth over two years — these are working figures only. Get real numbers on capacity, revenue target, and hours per month. *If exact figures aren't at hand, "let me pull that" is a fine answer here — precision can follow by email.*
8. What would you never change about how this firm works?
9. Walk me through the first ninety days with a new household. What actually happens, step by step?
10. "Looking under every rock in the creek" is in your document. What was the last rock, and what was under it?
11. Tell me about something you did for a client in the last month that took far more time than it was worth.
12. Describe your best client meeting this year. Then describe the worst one.
13. What did the previous owner do that you have already stopped doing? What have you deliberately kept?
14. What do clients most often misunderstand about what you actually do?
15. If you couldn't take someone on, who in this region would you send them to? Why that firm specifically?
16. What is on the walls of the office right now?
17. What part of the work do you actually enjoy most?
18. What is the hardest thing about running this firm right now?

THE CLIENTS

Now the people themselves, not as data points, as households.

1. When someone calls in for the first time, what do they literally say? Give me their actual words.
2. Who chose someone else in the last year? Do you know why, or are you guessing?
3. What do new clients usually get wrong about what you do?
4. What do your clients worry about at 2am?
5. How many of your clients' kids could actually name you?
6. What happens to a client's money when they die? Does the next generation know who you are?
7. Is there a service or piece of advice most clients would benefit from that they're not currently getting?

REFERRALS AND REPUTATION

Growth so far has been almost entirely word of mouth. This is where we get specific about how that actually works.

1. Walk me through the last eight households that came on board. How did each one find you?
2. How many of the 210 came with the firm when you bought it, and how many have you brought in yourself since December?
3. Name the three people outside this firm who have sent you the most business. What is your actual relationship with each of them?
A records question at heart — a rough answer live is fine, exact names and counts can follow.
4. Which accountants or attorneys do you already trust? Do you actually know if they send you business, or is that a guess?
5. When was the last time you asked someone for a referral, out loud, in those words?
6. What would make it easier for someone to refer you?
7. When a client refers you, is it usually to a friend or family member, or does it go through an accountant or attorney?
8. What boards, organizations, or community groups is anyone here already part of?
9. What do people in Waynesburg say about this firm?
10. Pittsburgh has heard of it. What do people there say, if they've heard of it at all?

THE MARKET

1. Who in this market do you respect, and what do they get right?
2. Whose marketing have you ever actually noticed?
3. What claim do all the other firms make that you would never make?
4. What could you say that a competitor honestly could not?

THE NAME AND THE BRAND

1. When you say Casteel out loud, what does it sound like to you?
2. What should someone feel in the first ten seconds on the website?
3. What is the wrong impression to give?
4. Should the brand feel local, regional, or neither?
5. Is there anything you would be embarrassed to put in front of a client?

THE TEAM AND THE FUTURE

1. What are you best at that nobody sees?
2. Is there something about the business you've been meaning to fix or improve but just haven't gotten to yet?
3. What would make the January 1 launch feel like a win to you, not just a deadline hit?
4. Have you ever written, spoken publicly, or been quoted anywhere? How did it go?

THE CHARACTER EXERCISE

Everyone writes their own answer down before anyone says anything out loud, then go around and read them. Where the three of them disagree matters more than where they agree. Chase every answer with "why that?" Don't try to get through all of these, pick eight or so and follow whichever one opens up.

Who the firm is

1. If you could choose any celebrity to be the face of your company, who would it be and why?
2. Now the opposite: which celebrity would be completely wrong as the face of the company, even though they're successful and plenty of people like them? What makes them wrong for us?
3. What's a business, in any industry, that treats people the way you want your clients treated?
4. Name a business you'd hate to be mistaken for. What is it about them?
5. If the firm had a soundtrack, what's track one?

What it's made of

6. If this firm were a vehicle, what is it? Be specific, make and model if you can picture it. Why that one?
7. If you gave every new client one physical object on the day they signed on, what would it be? Not paperwork, something they'd actually keep.
8. What's in this firm's toolbox that other firms around here don't carry?
9. Does this firm write a typed letter or a handwritten one?

Forced choices (make them pick one, no hedging)

10. Would you rather lose a client to a bigger firm or to a cheaper one?
11. Would you rather be the firm people recommend, or the firm people search for?
12. Sharp, or steady?
13. The firm that knows the most, or the firm that asks the best questions?
14. If you could only be known for one thing in this region, what is it?

Waynesburg

15. What's the most Waynesburg thing about this firm?
16. Who from around here, living or dead, would you want a picture of on the office wall? Why them?
17. If the firm picked up and moved to Pittsburgh tomorrow, what would it lose?

FOR THE 25TH

This is the logistics section: locking direction and naming an owner and a date for what has to be decided before launch.

1. What does the firm actually do day to day, in specifics?
2. Where do you want the firm to be in three to five years?
3. Who are the best clients, and what do they have in common?
4. Who does the firm want more of, and is there a minimum?
5. How do clients actually arrive, channel by channel, not just referrals?
6. Where do referrals actually come from?
7. Which professional relationships are worth building on?
8. What happens to next-generation relationships at transfer?
9. How far should Casteel reach geographically?
10. What has to be true on launch day, and what can follow?
11. Is anything blocking January 1 on name clearance?
12. October photography — what are the dates, who, and where?
13. What does each of you want marketing to do for you?
14. What is everyone most worried about?

Four decisions to force

You don't need all four fully resolved Friday, but leave with a named owner and a date for each.

15. **Suffix.** Financial, Wealth Management, or Asset Management. (Spelling is already settled: Casteel.)
16. **January 1.** Confirmed: a simple landing page, LinkedIn, and stationery live that day, full site continuing into Q1. Get Joshua's buy-in specifically on budget and capacity, since if scope creeps past "simple," this date is what breaks.
17. **Service tiers.** Joshua hands over the document he held back.
18. **Client-base analysis.** Joshua commits to a date for the data export, ideally two weeks out.

On the name. Push for the spelling at minimum, even if the suffix stays open. My recommendation is Casteel. Also ask who else gets a vote, a spouse or partner's opinion is better heard now than in November.

On compliance. Find out who handles it, Joshua says it's an outside firm rather than a person. Form ADV Part 1 Item 1.C and Form CRS both need amending promptly once the name change is legally effective, not at the annual update. There may be a transition window where client materials carry both names.

On tiers. Joshua flagged that he wanted to hand the service-tier strategy over separately. Friday is the moment to ask for it. The website can't lead with a flagship offering we haven't been shown.

Budget and capacity, ask out loud

These are the ones where the first answer and the real answer are different, you only get the second one by sitting in the pause.

19. How many new households a year do you actually want?
20. At what point does taking on more start to hurt the work?
21. What is the revenue number you're aiming at, and by when?
22. Beyond my fee, what are you willing to spend on photography, printing, and hosting?
23. How many hours a month will you personally give to this?
24. Are you willing to be written about, photographed, and on video?
25. Who besides you gets a vote on the name?

Don't accept a vague answer, especially on budget and capacity. If he says "whatever it takes," ask for a number, then ask what number would make him wince.

One I'll handle myself: what compliance actually permits around client stories and testimonials, and whether Joshua can post without pre-approval. Get the compliance contact directly rather than relaying it through him.

QUESTIONS FOR TIM AND HAYLEY

Ask them directly, by name. With the owner in the room, staff default to nodding, and putting a specific question to a specific person is the only way around that.

1. When a client calls in, what do they usually want? What is the most common reason the phone rings?
2. What do clients say about Joshua when he isn't standing there?
3. Which clients do you personally look forward to seeing come through the door?
4. What part of how we work do you think we are genuinely good at? What part frustrates you?
5. When someone at a cookout asks what you do for a living, what do you actually say?
6. What has changed around here since December, from where you sit?

Hold this one for a private moment, not the group: "What does Joshua believe about this firm that you're not sure is still true?" Nobody answers that honestly in front of the owner.

THE FOUNDER INTERVIEW

Save this for the end, alone with Joshua, once Tim and Hayley have gone. Do it in the car, driving Castile Run Road. Bring a camera, you'll want to scout photography while you're out there. Ask everything anyway, even what you already know, and let him tell it long.

Where the name came from

1. Where exactly is the house on Castile Run Road? What is still standing?
2. How do you know it was spelled with two E's? Where did you see that?
3. When did it change, and who changed it?
4. What does that road mean to you that it wouldn't mean to a stranger?

The family

5. Your document mentions ironworking, coal, and the early gas industry. Who specifically? Which generation, which mine, which mill?
6. Tell me about your grandfather. What did he do, and what was he like about money?
7. What is the family story that gets told at every holiday?
8. What did your parents believe about money, and what did they get right?

Why this firm

9. What was your role at the firm before you bought it, and how long were you there?
10. Why buy the firm you were already working at, instead of starting your own or going somewhere else?
11. What did you almost do instead? What scared you about it at the time?
12. What did you find when you got inside that you did not expect?
13. Who was Milinovich? What did he care about, and is he still around?
14. What are you keeping from him, and what are you quietly undoing?

What he actually believes

15. What is your first memory of money?
16. What do you believe about this work that most advisors would disagree with?
17. Have you ever told someone not to hire you? What happened?
18. Why does changing the name matter to you personally? What would be lost if you just kept Milinovich & Co.?
19. Ten years from now, what has to be true for this to have been worth it?

AFTER FRIDAY

Send me the recording or your notes, whichever you have, don't clean them up. Verbatim phrasing is more useful than a tidy summary.

Four specific things, beyond that:

- The eight most recent households and how each one found the firm
- The literal opening words people use when they call in
- Joshua's honest competitive set, in his own reasoning
- Photos of the office, including the walls

And separately, on their own time: the site's Discovery tab has a full set of **THINK IT THROUGH** questions waiting — things like the founder story behind buying the firm, what the firm is known for, what it charges for that gets pushback, which clients they'd most hate to lose. No deadline on those, and no need to rush them out during or right after Friday. Point Joshua, Tim, and Hayley to the site and let those fill in over the following week or two, whenever each of them actually has a quiet half hour with their own notes in front of them.

OPEN QUESTIONS I STILL HAVE

- Who are Tim and Hayley, and what do they do? It changes which questions land.
- Does Joshua own the firm outright, or are there partners or an outside stake?
- Is there an existing client-relationship system, and does it hold the data the spreadsheet asks for?
- Has anyone secured the domains yet, for both spellings?